But the alternatives that presented themselves—such as China—have also given little relief. In fact, in many instances, Chinese lending was linked to hidden strings and ungenerous refinancing terms. For the Global South, the challenges of sustainable financing were made worse by the global pandemic, geopolitical shocks, and little influence over major central banks' interest rates.

A further challenge relates to climate justice. The countries of the Global South are among the most vulnerable to climate change, being in tropical regions prone to heatwaves, tropical storms, droughts and floods. They include small island states for whom rising sea levels represent an existential threat. Many feel that the developed world has not been forthcoming with climate finance and technology sharing, has tried to walk back the notion of 'common but differentiated responsibility', and has downplayed adaptation efforts. Despite grand promises, successive Conferences of the Parties (COPs) of the UNFCCC have delivered less than many had hoped.

Three, many countries of the Global South proved particularly vulnerable to disrupted supply chains during the Covid-19 pandemic. They were often among the last to receive critical medical supplies, protective gear, medical devices, pharmaceuticals, and vaccines, with many developed and industrialized countries prioritizing their own domestic constituencies. Coordination among the Global South therefore assumed greater urgency.

Finally, the Russia–Ukraine war highlighted vulnerabilities in the Global South in terms of food and energy security. Energy prices spiked and impediments to the export of grain and fertilizer from Ukraine and Russia led to rising inflation and concerns about food availability in vulnerable countries. The strategic priorities of Russia, Europe, and the United States seemed to take precedence over these concerns.

Taken together, these trends have led to a renewed understanding that the Global South needs to coalesce and coordinate on these matters, despite their many other differences. India opted to take a role in channelling these concerns during its G20 presidency by holding a 'Voice of the Global South' virtual summit, inviting over 100 countries to participate. It also